



Parthenon

The temple of Athena, epitome of Classical Greek architecture, overlooking Athens from the Acropolis

The Parthenon is regarded as symbolizing the pinnacle of Classical Greek civilization, an exemplary expression of architecture of the Doric order given pride of place in the Acropolis, the citadel above the city of Athens. It was built to replace an older temple of Athena, which had been destroyed in the Persian invasion of 480 BCE. Along with other smaller temples and a grand entrance to the Acropolis, it was intended as a celebration of the Athenian victory over the invaders. The Parthenon, constructed from fine white marble from Mount Pentellicus, was the largest temple to have been built at that time, measuring 228 ft (70 m) long by 101 ft (31 m) wide.

The House of the Virgin

At the heart of the temple was an inner chamber that housed a huge statue of Athena Parthenos (Athena the Virgin) from which it derived its name, "the house of the virgin." Overseen by the sculptor Phidias, the architects Iktinos and Kallikratis developed a design incorporating elements of the new Ionic style into a basically Doric structure. This structure was then decorated with sculptures in the pediments and with friezes of relief panels above both outer and inner rows of columns.

Used as a Christian church from the 6th century and converted into a mosque after the Ottoman conquest of Athens in 1458, the Parthenon survived intact until 1687, when it was damaged during a Venetian bombardment of the city. In the early 19th century, many of the surviving sculptures were removed by Thomas Bruce, 7th Earl of Elgin, and are still, controversially, on display in the British Museum in London.



▷ MARBLE FRIEZE

Above the rows of columns were friezes of high-relief sculptures depicting gods and characters from Greek mythology.

The **lost statue of Athena Parthenos** by Phidias was made of **gold and ivory**

